



✿ THE FREE GUIDE · 15-22 AUGUST

# What *not* to do at Feria

For eight days Málaga throws the biggest party in the south: two ferias in one city, casetas that never ask for a ticket, and a pink bottle with a reputation. Most visitors get at least three of these wrong in their first afternoon. Here's the list — and what to do instead.

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# The eight *mistakes*

## 1 Looking for the party in the centre at night

The day feria ends at 18:00 sharp and the centre empties. After dark it all happens at [El Real \(Cortijo de Torres\)](#), until around six in the morning.

## 2 Skipping the day feria entirely

The other classic. From about 13:00 Calle Larios has live *verdiales* — Málaga's own folk music — and the old-town squares run concerts until 18:00. [Do both halves.](#)

## 3 Drinking Cartojal like it's sangria

Sweet, ice cold and 15% — stronger than most wine you drink at home, and it goes down like juice. [Pace yourself, and eat.](#)

## 4 Queuing for taxis, or worse, driving

[Bus F](#) links the centre and El Real 24 hours a day for [€2](#) — cash or card, no travel pass needed. Sixteen more night lines run 20:00–06:00 from every district.

## 5 Assuming the casetas are private

That's Seville's fair. In Málaga free entry is the rule — [if it sounds good, walk in](#). Nobody will stop you.

## 6 Wandering the centre in beachwear

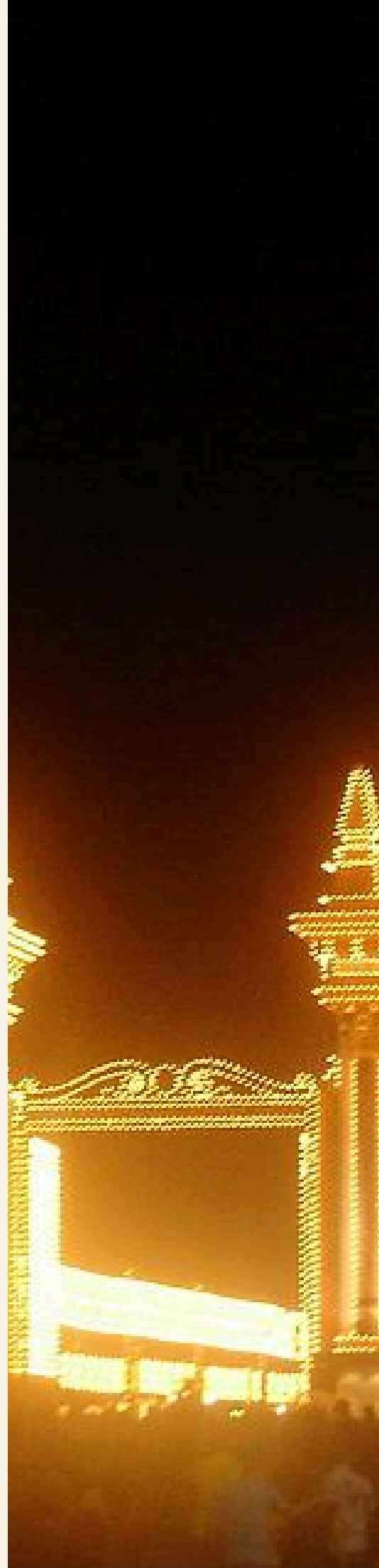
City ordinance, fines up to [€750](#). Ten minutes away on the seafront nobody blinks. It's about where, not what.

## 7 Planning a normal Wednesday on the 19th

It's a local holiday and the fair's big day — the whole city is out. [Lean in or stay by the pool](#); there is no in-between.

## 8 Carrying your whole life with you

A million people is a million people. Phone zipped, small cash, bag worn in front in the crush. Boring advice that works.





# The perfect *feria* day

**11:00****Beach first**

The feria doesn't wake up before you do. Morning swim, slow breakfast — you're saving your legs for a sixteen-hour day.

**13:00****Calle Larios, for the verdiales**

Groups from the three provincial styles play daily on Larios, **13:00–17:00** — hats stacked with flowers, ribbons and tiny mirrors, fiddles and cymbals. You will not hear this anywhere else on earth.

**14:30****First Cartojal, in the shade**

Small glass, ice cold, with something to eat beside it. The squares — Constitución, Las Flores, Obispo — all have music until 18:00.

**16:30****Retreat before it closes**

The centre winds down at 18:00 anyway. Leave while it's still good.

**17:30****Siesta. Non-negotiable**

The night runs until six. The locals sleep now, and the locals are the ones still dancing at five.

**20:30****Dress up, catch Bus F**

Night feria is dressed-up feria — summer dresses and shirts, not beach clothes. **€2, cash or card**, straight to the fairground.

**21:30****Walk in under the portada**

The lit gate of El Real is the photo of the week. Behind it: a temporary city of casetas, lights and noise that runs till dawn.

**22:30****Caseta-hop**

Free entry, remember. Follow the music you like — flamenco in one, pop in the next, sevillanas two doors down. Eat where the locals are standing three deep.

**1:00****The cacharritos**

The funfair side of El Real: the big wheel is the view of the whole glowing city of the fair.

**5:30****Churros before bed**

Hot chocolate and churros as the sky goes pale. This is how a feria day officially ends — anything earlier is surrender.



Verdiales on Calle Larios: Málaga's own music, daily 13:00–17:00 during feria. 🌸



## WHAT TO ORDER

# Drink and eat *the feria*

### Cartojal

*kar-to-HAL*

THE feria drink: a pale sweet moscatel from the hills east of the city, D.O. Málaga, in the unmissable pink bottle. Served at 6–8°C, by the glass everywhere. It is 15% — respect it and it will respect you.

### Espetos

*es-PEH-tos*

Sardines on a cane skewer, grilled over open fire in the beach chiringuitos — and August is their best month. The classic feria-week lunch before the evening shift.

### Pescaíto frito

*pes-ka-EE-to FREE-to*

Málaga's mixed fried fish — boquerones, calamares, adobo. Order a mix for the table in any caseta doing food and eat it standing up like everyone else.

### Churros & chocolate

*CHU-ros*

The dawn ritual. When the casetas finally wind down, the churros stands are where the whole fair ends up. Thick chocolate, no apologies, then bed.

✿ **Lucy's golden rule:** alternate. One Cartojal, one water, something fried in between. The people still standing at 6 am aren't tougher than you — they're just better at pacing.

# Say it like a *local*

## Feria

FEH-ree-ah

The fair — but for eight days it's less an event than a way of life. "¿Vas a la feria?" is the only small talk you need.

## El Real

el reh-AL

The fairground at Cortijo de Torres, where the night feria lives. "The Real" — locals never say the full name.

## Caseta

ka-SEH-ta

The tents-slash-clubhouses of the Real. In Málaga, free to enter — that word is doing a lot of work in this guide.

## Biznaga

biz-NA-ga

Jasmine buds pinned onto a dried thistle stalk — Málaga's flower, sold by *biznagueros* in white. It perfumes a whole street.

## Verdiales

behr-DYA-les

Málaga's ancient folk style: fiddles, cymbals, and hats piled with flowers, ribbons and mirrors. On Larios every feria afternoon.

## Cartojal

kar-to-HAL

Order it by name, ice cold ("bien frío"). Asking for sangria at feria marks you instantly.

## Farolillo

fa-ro-LEE-yo

The paper lanterns strung over every street. When the farolillos go up in early August, the whole city starts counting days.

## ¡Qué arte!

keh AR-teh

"What art!" — the highest compliment in Andalusia. For dancers, singers, or anyone doing anything with style.

**Why Wednesday the 19th** 🌸 The fair commemorates 19 August 1487, when Málaga was incorporated into the Crown of Castile by the Catholic Monarchs — which is why the 19th is a local holiday and the feria's big day. Shops close, the city sleeps in, and by night the Real is as full as it gets all week.

**The €750 rule, in full** 🌸 Málaga's coexistence ordinance allows fines up to €750 for walking the city centre in swimwear or bare-chested. On the seafront and at the beach bars nobody cares — the line is the old town. During feria week, when the centre is one big party at 2 pm, it's the easiest mistake to make.



# See you *at the feria*

Eight days, two ferias, one city that refuses to sleep. If this guide saves you one taxi queue or one Cartojal headache, it's done its job. Tag me from a caseta — I want to know which mistake you almost made.

✿ [@itslucyinthesouth](#)

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